

Session 1: Abraham and Sarah in the Biblical Imagination

Key Takeaways

- Jesus constantly appealed to the Hebrew Scriptures to talk about his identity and mission, and the stories of Avraham and Sarah were an important part of this.
- The rest of the Bible mentions Abraham and Sarah over 115 times, highlighting the crucial role they play in the story of the Bible.
- Mary saw God moving in her life and story as a continuation of the promises made to Avraham.

The Importance of Abraham and Sarah

Within the story of the Bible, there are few characters who rival the importance of Abraham and Sarah. Abraham is mentioned in nearly every part of the Bible, and the story of his journey from Babylon to Canaan, the tales of his failures and his faith, and the covenant promises that God makes to him are all foundational in the biblical story and in both Jewish and Christian traditions.

The way their names are pronounced in English comes from the Greek spelling and pronunciation. The original Hebrew pronunciation of their names is a bit different, and in the rest of these notes, their names will appear based on the Hebrew and not the Greek.

- Hebrew: אברהם / אברם, Avram/Avraham; שרה / שרי, Sarai/Sarah
- Greek: Ἀβραάμ, Abraam; Σαρρας, Sarras

The following is just a sample of how later biblical authors recall the story of Avraham and Sarai.

God's Covenant Promise to Avraham

Exodus 2:24 NIV

God heard their groaning and he remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac and with Jacob.

Leviticus 26:42 NIV

I will remember my covenant with Jacob and my covenant with Isaac and my covenant with Abraham, and I will remember the land.

Numbers 32:11 NIV

Because they have not followed me wholeheartedly, not one of those who were twenty years old or more when they came out of Egypt will see the land I promised on oath to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

Deuteronomy 1:8 NIV

See, I have given you this land. Go in and take possession of the land the LORD swore he would give to your fathers—to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob—and to their descendants after them.

Avraham's Journey to Canaan and God's Blessing

Exodus 32:12-13 NIV

¹² "Why should the Egyptians say, 'It was with evil intent that he brought them out, to kill them in the mountains and to wipe them off the face of the earth'? Turn from your fierce anger; relent and do not bring disaster on your people. ¹³ Remember your servants Abraham, Isaac and Israel, to whom you swore by your own self: 'I will make your descendants as numerous as the stars in the sky and I will give your descendants all this land I promised them, and it will be their inheritance forever.'"

Joshua 24:2-3 NIV

² Joshua said to all the people, "This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: 'Long ago your ancestors, including Terah the father of Abraham and Nahor, lived beyond the Euphrates River and worshiped other gods. ³ But I took your father Abraham from the land beyond the Euphrates and led him throughout Canaan and gave him many descendants.'"

Isaiah 51:2 NIV

... look to Abraham, your father, and to Sarai, who gave you birth. When I called him he was only one man, and I blessed him and made him many.

Ezekiel 33:24 NIV

"Son of man, the people living in those ruins in the land of Israel are saying, 'Abraham was only one man, yet he possessed the land. But we are many; surely the land has been given to us as our possession.'"

Avraham's Faith in God's Promise

John 8:39 NASB

They answered and said to him, "Abraham is our father." Jesus said to them, "If you are Abraham's children, do the deeds of Abraham."

Romans 4:19-20 NASB

¹⁹ Without becoming weak in faith he contemplated his own body, now as good as dead since he was about a hundred years old, and the deadness of Sarai's womb; ²⁰ yet, with respect to the promise of God, he did not waver in unbelief but grew strong in faith, giving glory to God ...

Hebrews 11:8 NASB

By faith Abraham, when he was called, obeyed by going out to a place which he was to receive for an inheritance; and he went out, not knowing where he was going.

Galatians 3:29 NASB

And if you belong to Christ, then you are Abraham's descendants, heirs according to promise.

Hebrews 11:11 NASB

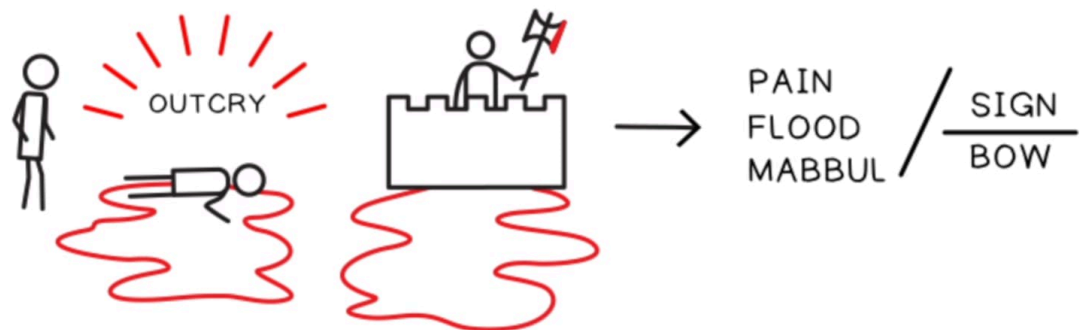
By faith even Sarai herself received ability to conceive, even beyond the proper time of life, since she considered him faithful who had promised.

James 2:21-22 NASB

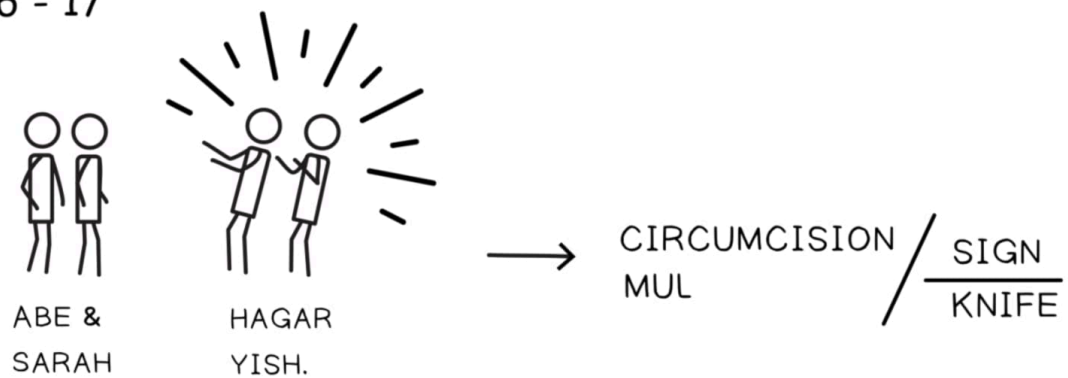
²¹ Was not Abraham our father justified by works when he offered up Isaac his son on the altar? ²² You see that faith was working with his works, and as a result of the works, faith was perfected ...

Isaiah 51 and the Avraham Story

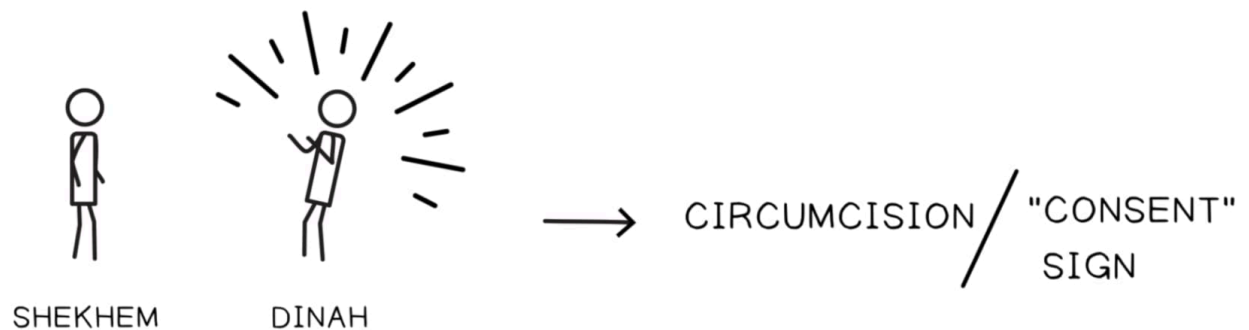
GEN 6 - 9



GEN 16 - 17



GEN 34



Isaiah 51 and the Avraham Story. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

How do Mary's song in Luke 1 and God's words through the prophet in Isaiah 51 describe the role of Avraham and Sarah's story in understanding God's purposes in every age?